

macOS Prompt Vocabulary

Common nouns and verbs for asking Codex to build native SwiftUI-first Mac apps.

Use these words to tell Codex what surface, behavior, framework, state, test, or release step you mean. The goal is precision, not memorizing Apple APIs.

Fast Prompt Recipe

- Name the app shape: windowed app, document-based app, menu bar app, utility app, or helper app.
- Name the desktop surfaces: menu bar, commands, toolbar, sidebar, inspector, settings window, sheet, panel, or popover.
- Name native integrations: file importer/exporter, drag and drop, keyboard shortcuts, undo manager, pasteboard, notifications, login item, and sandbox.
- Name implementation boundaries: SwiftUI first, AppKit interop only for missing platform behavior.
- Name distribution path: Mac App Store, Developer ID outside the store, sandbox, hardened runtime, notarization, stapling, DMG, or PKG.

Fill In These Slots

Slot	Example wording
App type	Build a native SwiftUI macOS menu bar app...
Windows	Use a main window, Settings scene, and optional inspector panel...
Navigation	Use NavigationSplitView with sidebar, content list, and detail editor...
Desktop controls	Add toolbar items, menu commands, keyboard shortcuts, drag and drop, and undo/redo...
Files	Support open panel import, save panel export, security-scoped bookmarks, and Reveal in Finder...
Quality bar	Support Command +/- text scaling, accessibility labels, keyboard navigation, unit tests, and UI tests...
Release path	Prepare a Developer ID build: sign, enable hardened runtime, notarize, staple, and package as DMG...

Project, App Shape, And Xcode Nouns

Use these when the work is about creating the app, choosing a Mac app shape, or setting up build and signing.

Term	Means	Useful prompt wording
macOS app	A native desktop application installed on macOS.	Build a native SwiftUI macOS app.
SwiftUI	Apple's declarative UI framework, preferred for new Mac UI unless the project is AppKit-first.	Use SwiftUI for the main interface.
AppKit	The older native Mac UI framework, still needed for some desktop behaviors.	Use narrow AppKit interop for the missing window behavior.
Xcode project	The .xcodeproj that owns targets, files, settings, and schemes.	Create an Xcode project named ClipShelf.
target	The app, helper, extension, or test bundle that Xcode builds.	Add a helper target only if launch-at-login requires it.
scheme	The named Xcode build/run/test/profile configuration.	Build and test the ClipShelf scheme.
bundle identifier	The unique reverse-DNS app id.	Use bundle identifier com.cseibert.ClipShelf.
entitlement	A signed permission such as sandbox access, app groups, iCloud, or keychain access.	Add only the entitlements required for file access and notifications.
sandbox	A macOS security container that limits file, network, and system access.	Enable App Sandbox and use security-scoped bookmarks for user-selected folders.
hardened runtime	A security requirement for Developer ID notarization.	Enable hardened runtime for the Release build.
asset catalog	The catalog for app icons, colors, and image assets.	Add the macOS app icon to Assets.xcassets.
menu bar app	An app whose main presence is a status item in the system menu bar.	Build this as a MenuBarExtra app.
document-based app	An app centered on opening, editing, and saving documents.	Use a document-based app with FileDocument.
helper app	A companion executable, often for login items or privileged work.	Do not add a helper app unless the requirement needs it.
settings scene	SwiftUI scene for app preferences.	Add a Settings scene with General and Advanced tabs.
Swift package	A dependency managed by Swift Package Manager.	Add dependencies as Swift packages and keep versions pinned.

Window, Menu, And Navigation Nouns

Use these to describe desktop structure. Mac apps usually need menus and keyboard access in addition to visible buttons.

Term	Means	Useful prompt wording
window	A top-level desktop container.	Use a resizable main window with a sensible minimum size.
WindowGroup	SwiftUI scene for one or more windows of the same kind.	Use WindowGroup for the main app window.
single-window app	An app that keeps work in one main window.	Keep this as a single-window app.
multi-window app	An app that can open multiple independent windows.	Support multiple project windows.
panel	A floating utility window, often non-document content.	Use an inspector panel only if it needs to float separately.
sheet	A modal surface attached to a window.	Present destructive confirmation as a sheet.
popover	A small transient panel anchored to a control.	Show quick filters in a popover from the toolbar button.
menu bar	The system menu row at the top of the screen.	Add File, Edit, View, Window, and Help menu commands as appropriate.
command	A menu item or keyboard-invoked action declared in SwiftUI.	Add commands for New, Import, Export, and Toggle Sidebar.
keyboard shortcut	A Command-key or other key equivalent for a command.	Add Command-N for New and Command-E for Export.
toolbar	Actions and controls at the top of a window.	Add a toolbar with Add, Search, Filter, and Inspector buttons.
sidebar	A leading navigation column.	Use a sidebar for projects and smart lists.
NavigationSplitView	A two- or three-column desktop layout.	Use NavigationSplitView with sidebar, list, and detail columns.
inspector	A trailing panel for editing properties of the selected item.	Add an inspector for metadata and advanced settings.
status item	A menu bar icon or control.	Use a status item to show sync state.
Dock menu	Context menu shown from the app icon in the Dock.	Add Dock menu commands for New Note and Sync Now.

Controls, Layout, And Desktop Interaction Nouns

Use these to describe controls that feel natural on macOS and interactions desktop users expect.

Term	Means	Useful prompt wording
List	A selectable collection of rows.	Use a List with multi-selection for items.
Table	A multi-column data view.	Use a Table for sortable file records.
Outline view	A hierarchical tree list.	Use an outline view for nested folders.
Form	A settings or editor layout with labeled controls.	Use a Form for preferences.
split view	Resizable panes.	Use a split view so the sidebar and editor can resize.
scroll view	A scrollable content region.	Wrap long settings content in a scroll view.
button	A clickable command.	Use icon toolbar buttons with tooltips.
checkbox	A binary setting.	Use checkboxes for independent settings.
radio group	A mutually exclusive choice set.	Use a radio group for the default export format.
pop-up button	A compact menu for choosing one value.	Use a pop-up button for sort order.
segmented control	A compact mode switch.	Use a segmented control for list, board, and timeline modes.
text field	A single-line editable value.	Use a text field for the project name.
search field	A search input, often in toolbar or sidebar.	Add a search field in the toolbar.
color well	A Mac control for choosing colors.	Use a color well for project tint.
drag and drop	Pointer interaction for moving or importing items.	Support dragging files into the window to import them.
context menu	Secondary-click actions for an item.	Add a context menu with Rename, Duplicate, Reveal in Finder, and Delete.
undo manager	System undo/redo integration.	Register rename and delete operations with the undo manager.
pasteboard	macOS clipboard APIs.	Support copy and paste for selected rows.
accessibility label	VoiceOver-readable name for controls.	Add accessibility labels to icon-only toolbar buttons.

Files, State, And System Integration Nouns

Use these when the app touches the file system, keeps state, or integrates with desktop services.

Term	Means	Useful prompt wording
file importer	System UI for choosing files to open.	Use a file importer for CSV import.
file exporter	System UI for saving generated files.	Use a file exporter for Markdown and PDF export.
open panel	AppKit file chooser for opening files or folders.	Use an open panel if SwiftUI fileImporter cannot express the folder selection.
save panel	AppKit file chooser for saving a file.	Use a save panel for choosing export location.
security-scoped bookmark	Persistent permission to user-selected files or folders in sandboxed apps.	Store security-scoped bookmarks for watched folders.
Reveal in Finder	Command to open Finder with a file selected.	Add Reveal in Finder to the row context menu.
recent documents	System menu and behavior for recently opened files.	Add recent-document support for document-based workflows.
UserDefaults	Small preferences storage.	Store sidebar visibility in UserDefaults.
Keychain	Secure secret storage.	Store API tokens in Keychain.
SwiftData	Modern Swift persistence framework.	Use SwiftData for local app records.
CloudKit	Apple iCloud sync backend.	Sync settings and records with CloudKit if requested.
notification	System notification delivered by macOS.	Show a local notification when export completes.
login item	A helper or app registration that starts at login.	Add a launch-at-login toggle using a login item.
App Intents	System actions used by Shortcuts, Spotlight, and Siri.	Add App Intents for quick capture and sync now.
Quick Look	System preview for files.	Add Quick Look preview for selected attachments.
Spotlight	System search indexing.	Index documents in Spotlight only if needed.

Testing, Performance, And Diagnostics Nouns

Use these when asking Codex to verify behavior or diagnose a local Mac app.

Term	Means	Useful prompt wording
unit test	A focused test for logic.	Add unit tests for import parsing and export formatting.
UI test	An XCTest that drives the running app.	Add a UI test for importing a file and exporting a summary.
preview	A SwiftUI preview for a view.	Add previews for the toolbar, empty state, and detail editor.
sample data	Fake records used in previews and tests.	Create sample data for previews without hitting the network.
Instruments	Apple profiling tools for memory, CPU, hangs, energy, and leaks.	Profile table scrolling with Instruments if performance regresses.
memory graph	Xcode tool for finding retained objects and leaks.	Use a memory graph if windows are not deallocated.
crash log	A report from a crashed app.	Symbolicate the crash log and identify the failing stack frame.
console log	Runtime logs visible in Console or Xcode.	Add structured logs around sync start, success, and failure.
sandbox violation	A denied operation caused by missing permission or entitlement.	Investigate the sandbox violation and add the narrowest entitlement or file permission flow.
accessibility audit	Review for VoiceOver, keyboard navigation, contrast, and text scaling.	Audit keyboard navigation and VoiceOver labels.
text scaling	Command +/- support for app content size in this user's local preference.	Support Command +/- to scale content text.
keyboard navigation	Using Tab, arrows, and shortcuts without the pointer.	Make the list, toolbar, and inspector keyboard navigable.

Verbs That Help Codex Act

Use verbs that name the engineering move. They reduce ambiguity more than extra adjectives do.

Verb	Means	Useful prompt wording
scaffold	Create the project or feature skeleton.	Scaffold a SwiftUI macOS app with tests and a Makefile.
implement	Build real behavior, not placeholders.	Implement import, edit, export, and undo end to end.
bridge	Use AppKit from SwiftUI for a missing native behavior.	Bridge to NSOpenPanel for folder selection.
extract	Move repeated UI or logic into a reusable type.	Extract the sidebar row into a reusable view.
wire	Connect UI, commands, state, services, and persistence.	Wire the toolbar Export button to the file exporter.
bind	Connect controls to state.	Bind the inspector fields to the selected record.
present	Show a sheet, popover, or panel.	Present preferences in the Settings scene.
focus	Move keyboard focus to a control.	Focus the search field when the user presses Command-F.
activate	Bring the app or window forward.	Activate the app when the menu bar item opens the main window.
resize	Change or constrain window and pane size.	Set a minimum window size and remember the last size.
import	Read user-selected external files.	Import CSV files through a file importer.
export	Write data to a user-selected file.	Export selected rows to Markdown.
persist	Save app data locally.	Persist records with SwiftData.
remember	Store UI preference or recent state.	Remember sidebar visibility and selected project.
register	Attach actions to system services.	Register undo operations for edits.
sign	Apply a code signature.	Sign the Release app with the Developer ID Application certificate.
notarize	Submit Mac software to Apple's notary service.	Notarize the Developer ID build.
staple	Attach the notarization ticket to the app or package.	Staple the notarization ticket before packaging the DMG.
package	Create a distributable artifact.	Package the notarized app in a DMG.
submit	Send a build or metadata to Apple.	Submit the Mac App Store build to App Review.

Ambiguous Words To Replace

These are common non-engineer words that can make an agent guess. Replace them with the platform terms on the right.

Instead of	Probably means	Say this instead
desktop app	native macOS app, Catalyst app, Electron app, or web app	Build a native SwiftUI macOS app.
top bar	menu bar, window toolbar, or title bar	Add a toolbar item and a matching menu command.
tray icon	menu bar extra or status item	Build this as a MenuBarExtra app.
popup	popover, sheet, panel, alert, or menu	Use a popover for quick filters and a sheet for editing.
preferences	Settings scene, settings window, or UserDefaults-backed settings	Add a Settings scene with General and Advanced tabs.
open file dialog	file importer or NSOpenPanel	Use fileImporter for simple file selection.
save dialog	file exporter or NSSavePanel	Use fileExporter for Markdown export.
background app	menu bar app, launch agent, helper app, or login item	Create a menu bar app with a launch-at-login option.
installer	DMG, PKG, Mac App Store, or Developer ID distribution	Package a notarized Developer ID app as a DMG.
make it native	SwiftUI/AppKit controls, menus, keyboard shortcuts, sandbox, HIG behavior	Use native macOS controls, menu commands, keyboard shortcuts, and sandbox-safe file access.

Release And Publishing Words

Term or step	Prompt wording
Mac App Store	Prepare an App Store signed archive, sandbox as required, upload to App Store Connect, and submit for App Review.
Developer ID	Prepare distribution outside the Mac App Store with Developer ID signing.
App Sandbox	Enable sandbox and add only required file, network, app group, iCloud, or keychain entitlements.
Hardened runtime	Enable hardened runtime for notarized Developer ID distribution.
Archive	Create a Release archive from Xcode.
Notarize	Submit the signed app or package to Apple's notary service.
Staple	Attach the notary ticket to the app, DMG, or PKG before distribution.
DMG	Package the app in a disk image for direct download distribution.
PKG	Use a package installer when the app needs installer behavior beyond drag-to-Applications.
Sparkle	Only use a third-party updater such as Sparkle if the project already uses it or explicitly requests direct-download auto-update.

Example Prompts

New macOS app

Build a native SwiftUI macOS app named ClipShelf. Use a single resizable main window with NavigationSplitView: sidebar for collections, content table for clips, and detail inspector for metadata. Add toolbar items with tooltips, File/Edit/View menu commands, Command-N and Command-F shortcuts, drag and drop import, SwiftData persistence, undo/redo, accessibility labels, unit tests, and a UI test for creating a clip.

Menu bar utility

Build a SwiftUI MenuBarExtra app that shows sync status and quick actions. Include Open Main Window, Sync Now, Pause, Settings, and Quit commands. Add a launch-at-login toggle, local notifications for sync failures, Keychain storage for tokens, and narrow AppKit interop only if needed for activation behavior.

Direct download release

Prepare a Developer ID release. Verify bundle identifier, signing certificate, sandbox entitlements, hardened runtime, version, app icon, and privacy strings. Archive the app, notarize it, staple the ticket, package it as a DMG, and document any manual Apple account steps still required.

Reference Anchors

Source	URL
Apple SwiftUI documentation	https://developer.apple.com/documentation/swiftui
Apple AppKit documentation	https://developer.apple.com/documentation/appkit
Apple Human Interface Guidelines	https://developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines
Xcode Mac packaging	https://developer.apple.com/documentation/xcode/packaging-mac-software-for-distribution
Apple notarization	https://developer.apple.com/documentation/security/notarizing-macos-software-before-distribution
App Store Connect App Review overview	https://developer.apple.com/help/app-store-connect/manage-submissions-to-app-review/overview-of-submitting-for-review/